

DISSOLVE™

A DESIGN RATIONALE

IMED3304 – Interactive Media Design

01 - THE PRODUCT

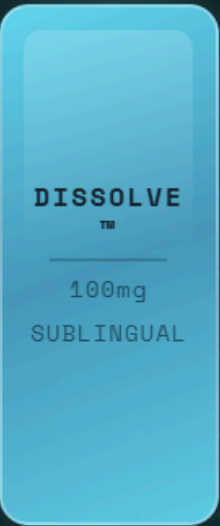
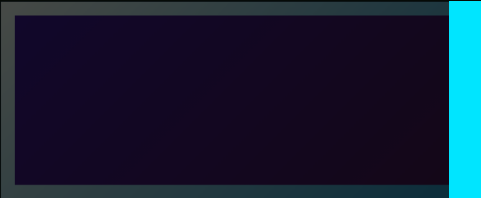
What is DISSOLVE™?

A fictional sublingual strip claiming to enhance memory, confidence, and reality. It dissolves under your tongue in 45 seconds. Or 45 hours. Time may vary. Your perception is not reliable.

- SUBLINGUAL
- 100MG
- SIDE EFFECTS APPLY

"Dissolves in seconds. Like your sense of self."

Background: Shrek's swamp house fades to black as you scroll deeper.
The world you came from disappears. The product takes over.



Absurd side effects aren't a list. They're an experience.

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THE OBVIOUS APPROACH

- Show a numbered list of side effects
- User reads passively, detached
- Clinical. Forgettable. Normal.
- Side effects stay on the page
- User feels nothing unusual

RESULT

Amusing. Forgettable. Safe.

THE DISSOLVE™ APPROACH

- User is made to live the side effects
- A creature runs across THEIR screen
- Farquaad judges them personally
- The page gaslights on second open
- A philosophy question ambushes them

"The side effect IS the website.

The website IS the side effect."

Every decision was intentional. Even the broken ones.

COLOUR PALETTE

Dark → Neon → Red



Black = void.
Swamp green = origin.
Cyan = the product.
Red = danger.
Each color is a story beat, not a preference..

TYPOGRAPHY

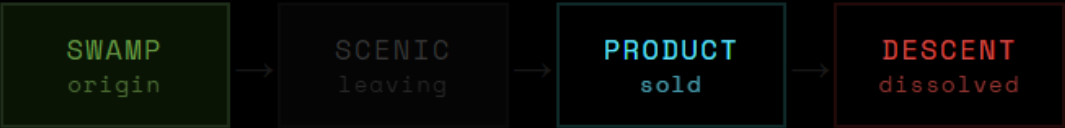
Two voices, two personalities

Space Mono **CLINICAL. COLD.**
Quicksand Human. Warm. Dissolving.

Space Mono = the product talking. Quicksand = you. The tension between them is the design.

SCROLL JOURNEY

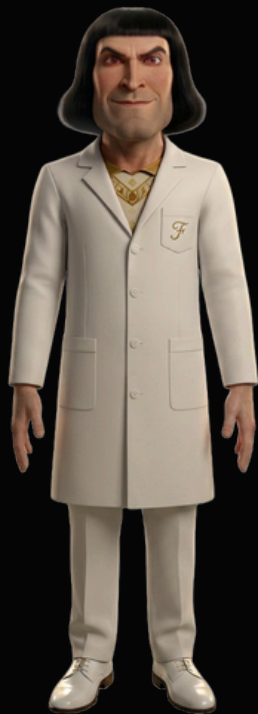
Three zones, one descent



The background literally darkeness as you scroll.
Green lush to pure black. The world dies as the product sells

Every good product has a mascot. DISSOLVE™ has two threats.

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Dr. Farquaad

AUTHORITY · JUDGMENT · THE SCIENTIST

Appears uninvited from the corner of the screen. Says nothing useful. Makes you feel you've done something wrong without specifying what. He is every approval process you've ever feared. His lines are pulled directly from Shrek; which makes them worse.

"I'm not the monster here, YOU are!"
"Some of you may lose yourselves. That's a risk I'm willing to take."



The Creature

LOST AUTHENTICITY · THE SELF · ESCAPE

An animated SVG cat that runs across the screen every 15–40 seconds. It's your authentic self fleeing the product. It runs faster each sighting. After the 5th appearance, it stops running. It just watches. That is the moment the strip has worked.

"The creature runs across your screen.
It's faster than last time.
Or maybe you're just slower."

The list gets worse every time you open it. That is not a bug.

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01

FIRST OPEN

Screen shakes. 20 side effects load with a glitch-reveal animation. Each line corrupts cyan - red - white before settling. Clinical. Readable. Deceptively calm.

NORMAL

02

SECOND OPEN

Red message appears: "Funny... this list looks different from last time. Doesn't it?" The list has not changed. You are not sure. Random lines re-glitch while you read.

GASLIGHTING

03

THIRD OPEN

After closing, a full-screen philosophical overlay: "Are the side effects getting worse... or are you just paying attention now?" Tap anywhere to dismiss. If you want to.

EXISTENTIAL

04+

FOURTH+ OPEN

"You've opened this four times. The strip doesn't exist. The chaos was always you. ... or was it?" There is no correct number of times to open this modal.

DISSOLVED

Discomfort is a UX decision. Every broken thing is intentional.

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BROKEN TIMER

Counts up, freezes, jumps forward, occasionally goes backward. You genuinely cannot trust how long you’ve been here. Currently shows 2026, but the footer glitches to 1504, 3307, then snaps back. So, when was this company founded? Nobody knows, it seems.

→ Time is unreliable. So is the product.



MUTATING TITLE

DISSOLVE™ → DISSOLVE? → DISSOLVE?? → ??? → DISSOLVE... The brand itself is unstable. Cycles every 8–20 seconds. You can’t even trust the name of what you’re taking.

→ If the brand dissolves, so do you.



CURSOR DRIFT

Custom pill-shaped cursor that lags behind real mouse position and randomly drifts 0.5–3px. You’re not fully in control of where you’re pointing. Small. Subtle. Genuinely unsettling after 30 seconds.

→ Agency is an illusion. Use it wisely.



GASLIGHT TOASTS

Bottom-center popups trigger after creature sightings, tab switching, and scroll depth: "Bruh you’re schizo as hell.. Not looking good.." , "Does the strip cause this... or do you need the strip because of this?"

→ The page accuses you of its own crimes.

The product is working. The designer is not finished.

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01 Audio whispers

Faint Web Audio API drone that rises in pitch as you scroll deeper. A whispered "dissolve" via Speech Synthesis every 35–60 seconds, barely audible, pitched low. Static crackle reacting to Farquaad appearing and the creature running.

02 Creature escalation

After 5 sightings, the creature grows slightly larger each run. By sighting 10, it walks slowly instead of running. It has accepted something. By sighting 15, it stops and faces the user. The page does nothing. That's the point.

03 Fake clinical trial ID

A "TRIAL ID: DXV-0" in the footer updating in real time, as if a live study is ongoing. Clicking it opens a redacted document. Some sections are unredacted. They are worse than the side effects.

Everyone would make a list. So I didn't.

CONCEPT JOURNEY

01 The reframe

The brief said absurd side effects. First instinct: a funny numbered list. Then I realised that is what everyone does. What if the user experienced the side effects instead of reading them? That became the entire philosophy: Live It, Don't List It.

02 What changed along the way

The pill became a sublingual strip because dissolves had to be literal. The creature started as an emoji, then became a full SVG based on Renee French's Ivey No. 106. Farquaad went from a static appearance to 9 reactive speech bubble lines. The creature ran at fixed speed until testing showed it needed to escalate.

03 User testing

Friends didn't notice the cursor drift so the frequency was increased. The creature was too fast to catch so early sightings were slowed down and made progressively faster each time.

CONSTRAINTS

BUILT

Creature mechanics

Farquaad + 9 lines

Modal gaslighting

Broken timer

Single HTML file

Cursor drift

CUT

~~Audio whispers~~

~~Creature escalation~~

~~Fake trial ID~~